

ACTIVE NOISE CANCELLATION IMPLEMENTATION AND DSP TECHNIQUES

(A dissertation submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements of Bachelor of Technology in Electronics & Communication Engineering of the Maulana Abul Kalam Azad University of Technology, West Bengal)

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Submitted by

SATYAM MISHRA [Roll No: 23101105017]

SHIVAM SINGH [Roll No: 23101105015]

ALOK DUBEY [Roll No: 23101105027]

Under the guidance of

Prof. Tanmay Paul

Department of Electronics & Communication Engineering



Jalpaiguri Government Engineering College

A Govt. Autonomous Engg. College

(Affiliated to Maulana Abul Kalam Azad University of Technology)

Jalpaiguri – 735102, WB, India



Jalpaiguri Government Engineering College

A Govt. Autonomous Engg. College

(Affiliated to Maulana Abul Kalam Azad University of Technology)

Jalpaiguri – 735102, WB, India

Certificate of Approval

This is to certify that the project report on “**Active Noise Cancellation Implementation and DSP Techniques**” is a record of bonafide work, carried out by **Satyam Mishra, Shivam Singh, Alok Dubey** under my guidance and supervision.

In my opinion, the report in its present form is in conformity as specified by **Jalpaiguri Government Engineering College** and as per regulations of the Maulana Abul Kalam Azad University of Technology (MAKAUT). To the best of my knowledge the results presented here are original in nature and worthy of incorporation in project report for the B.Tech. program in Electronics & Communication in the academic year 2025-2026.

.....
Signature of
Examiner

.....
Signature of
Supervisor

.....
Signature of
Head, Dept of ECE, JGEC



Jalpaiguri Government Engineering College

A Govt. Autonomous Engg. College

(Affiliated to Maulana Abul Kalam Azad University of Technology)

Jalpaiguri – 735102, WB, India

Undertaking

We, **Satyam Mishra** (Roll No. 23101105017), **Shivam Singh** (Roll No. 23101105015), **Alok Dubey** (Roll No. 23101105027), students of the final year B.Tech in Electronics & Communication Engineering at Jalpaiguri Government Engineering College, hereby declare that the project report entitled “**Active Noise Cancellation Implementation and DSP Techniques**” submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the award of the degree of Bachelor of Technology of the Maulana Abul Kalam Azad University of Technology, West Bengal, is an authentic record of our own work carried out during the academic year 2025–2026 under the supervision of **Prof. Tanmay Paul**, Department of Electronics & Communication Engineering, Jalpaiguri Government Engineering College.

We further declare that the matter embodied in this project report has not been submitted by us for the award of any other degree or diploma of this or any other university or institution.

.....
Satyam Mishra

Roll: 23101105017

.....
Shivam Singh

Roll: 23101105015

.....
Alok Dubey

Roll: 23101105027

Date: _____

Place: Jalpaiguri



Jalpaiguri Government Engineering College

A Govt. Autonomous Engg. College

(Affiliated to Maulana Abul Kalam Azad University of Technology)

Jalpaiguri – 735102, WB, India

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.....
Satyam Mishra

Roll: 23101105017

.....
Shivam Singh

Roll: 23101105015

.....
Alok Dubey

Roll: 23101105027

Date: _____

Place: Jalpaiguri

Abstract

Active Noise Cancellation (ANC) is a technique that uses active signal processing to reduce unwanted acoustic noise. This project report documents the design and implementation of a real-time ANC system using adaptive filtering algorithms. The system architecture integrates microphones, digital signal processing units, and control software to capture ambient noise and generate an anti-noise signal that destructively interferes with the original noise. Key topics covered include the theory of ANC, adaptive filter algorithms (LMS and RLS), the real-time audio processing pipeline, and performance evaluation. We demonstrate that the implemented system can attenuate various types of noise, achieving significant signal-to-noise ratio (SNR) improvements in simulations and experiments. The report concludes with discussions of advantages, limitations, and future extensions of the ANC approach.

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0.1 Introduction

Noise pollution is a pervasive problem in many environments, leading to hearing impairment and reduced speech intelligibility. Active Noise Cancellation (ANC) is an emerging solution that uses signal processing techniques to attenuate unwanted sound by generating an anti-noise waveform. ANC systems rely on the principle of superposition, creating a destructive interference that cancels out the original noise. Unlike passive methods (soundproofing) which are effective mainly at high frequencies, ANC actively senses the noise and adapts in real time. There is a need for an active system that can continuously sense the noise and adaptively generate a canceling signal. This project specifically addresses the challenge of designing and implementing an ANC system that operates in real-time to attenuate unwanted sound. The system must acquire live audio, process it quickly, and output an anti-noise signal through a speaker.

The remainder of this report is organized as follows: Section 2 defines the problem; Section 3 lists project objectives. Section 4 reviews existing noise mitigation systems and their limitations. Section 5 outlines the proposed ANC solution. Section 6 describes the system architecture. Section 7 discusses the technology stack used. Section 8 explains the methodology and development process. Section 9 details the adaptive filtering algorithms employed. Sections 10–13 cover the theory of ANC, digital signal processing concepts, and algorithm discussions. Section 14 discusses real-time constraints, followed by Section 15 on frequency analysis. Sections 16–18 describe implementation details, code structure, and key code explanations. Section 19 presents flowcharts and Section 20 shows system diagrams. Sections 21–22 discuss testing and results analysis. Finally, Sections 23–25 list advantages, limitations, and future scope, and Section 26 concludes the report.

0.2 Problem Statement

In many environments such as vehicles, industrial settings, and consumer electronics, ambient noise can significantly degrade comfort and communication. Traditional noise reduction (passive isolation) is often bulky and ineffective at low frequencies. There is a need for an active system that can continuously monitor noise and generate an anti-noise signal to cancel it. Specifically, this project addresses the challenge of designing and implementing an ANC system that operates in real-time to attenuate unwanted sound. The proposed system must acquire live microphone input, process it with an adaptive algorithm, and produce an anti-noise output. It should handle non-stationary noise and maintain system stability while providing measurable noise reduction.

0.3 Objectives

The primary objectives of this project are:

- To study and implement the theory of active noise cancellation using adaptive filters.
- To design a real-time audio processing pipeline that captures noise and outputs an anti-noise signal.
- To implement and compare adaptive filtering algorithms (LMS and RLS) for ANC.
- To analyze system performance in terms of noise reduction and computational requirements.
- To document system design, code, and testing comprehensively.

0.4 Existing System

Existing noise control techniques include passive methods (earmuffs, insulation) and older ANC designs. Passive methods suffer from weight and size issues at low frequencies. Earlier ANC systems often used fixed filters or single-reference setups, with limited adaptability. According to Kuo and Panahi, modern ANC systems (developed since the 1980s) leverage digital adaptive algorithms and powerful DSP hardware. However, many legacy systems still fail to achieve ideal cancellation due to suboptimal filter tuning and hardware constraints. Passive control is effective only when physical barriers suffice; active control becomes preferable when low-frequency noise dominates. This project improves upon existing approaches by using real-time adaptive filters and multiple microphones to enhance cancellation performance.

0.5 Proposed System

The proposed system is a multi-microphone ANC architecture with a digital adaptive controller. As shown in Figure 3, the system uses one **Primary Microphone** to capture the combined signal of environmental noise and any desired audio, and another **Reference Microphone** positioned closer to the noise source to capture correlated noise. An adaptive filter (LMS or RLS) processes the reference noise and generates a canceling signal sent to a speaker or headphone output. The **Error Microphone** downstream measures the residual noise (error signal), which is fed back into the adaptive algorithm to update filter coefficients.

Key features of the proposed system:

- **Adaptive Algorithm:** Implements LMS and RLS filters that update their coefficients in real time based on the error signal.
- **Real-Time Processing:** Audio is processed in buffered frames to meet low-latency requirements.
- **Modularity:** The software is modular, allowing easy integration or replacement of filter algorithms.
- **Visualization Tools:** Frequency spectrum analysis and waveform plots for offline analysis of system behavior.

0.6 System Architecture

Figure ?? illustrates the high-level system architecture. The primary components are:

- **Primary Microphone:** Captures the combined signal of environmental noise and any desired audio.
- **Reference Microphone:** Captures noise near the source, providing a correlated noise reference.
- **ADC/DAC Interface:** Converts analog microphone signals to digital and vice versa for output.
- **Adaptive Filter Block:** Implements the LMS or RLS algorithm to adaptively shape the anti-noise waveform.
- **Speaker Output:** Emits the anti-noise to interfere with the primary noise at the listener position.
- **Control Software:** Coordinates data flow, invokes DSP routines, and handles parameter settings.

Each block is implemented primarily in software, with audio hardware interfaced through APIs. The control software (written in Python) handles audio capture and playback, then passes data to the adaptive filter block. Filter outputs feed the speaker, and error measurements refine the filter weights. This closed-loop architecture ensures continuous adaptation to changing noise conditions.

0.7 Technology Stack

The system leverages the following technologies and tools:

- **Programming Language:** Python 3.x for rapid development and access to scientific libraries.
- **Audio Interface:** PyAudio (PortAudio) for low-latency audio capture and playback.
- **Numerical Libraries:** NumPy and SciPy for efficient array operations, filtering, and FFT computations.
- **Visualization:** Matplotlib for plotting waveforms and spectra (used in offline analysis).
- **Development Tools:** A standard PC or laptop running Windows/Linux, with requisite drivers for audio hardware.

Python was chosen for its ease of use and availability of signal processing libraries. The modular design allows components to be tested independently, and future porting to compiled languages or embedded platforms is possible if needed.

0.8 Methodology

The project methodology involved several phases:

1. **Literature Review:** Studied ANC principles and adaptive filters from textbooks and papers.
2. **Algorithm Selection:** Chose LMS and RLS algorithms due to their widespread use and contrasting characteristics.
3. **Simulation:** Developed prototype code to test adaptive filters on prerecorded signals (e.g., synthetic noise added to samples), tuning parameters (step size, filter length).
4. **System Design:** Defined system architecture and data flow. Created audio I/O code to interface with microphones and speakers.
5. **Implementation:** Wrote modular code for each component (audio capture, adaptive filter, output) and integrated them.
6. **Testing:** Conducted experiments using both simulated and real noises. Measured noise reduction metrics and visualized results.
7. **Iteration and Refinement:** Adjusted filter parameters and algorithm choices based on performance data (e.g., convergence speed, stability).

8. **Documentation:** Compiled design choices, code explanations, and test results into this report.

Flowcharts in Section 0.19 illustrate the operational flow. The development process ensured each module worked correctly before full system integration.

0.9 Algorithms Used

0.9.1 LMS (Least Mean Squares) Algorithm

The LMS algorithm is a simple adaptive filtering method that updates filter weights to minimize the mean square error. Given a reference input vector $\mathbf{x}(n)$ (noise samples) and a primary (desired) signal $d(n)$, the LMS update rule is:

$$e(n) = d(n) - \mathbf{w}^T(n) \mathbf{x}(n), \quad (1)$$

$$\mathbf{w}(n+1) = \mathbf{w}(n) + \mu e(n) \mathbf{x}(n), \quad (2)$$

where $\mathbf{w}(n)$ is the weight vector and μ is the step size. Here $e(n)$ is the error (residual noise at the error microphone). LMS employs a gradient-descent approach to minimize the cost function (mean squared error). Its computational complexity is low (linear in filter length), making it suitable for real-time use. However, convergence speed depends on the choice of μ and the signal properties.

0.9.2 RLS (Recursive Least Squares) Algorithm

The RLS algorithm solves a weighted least-squares problem recursively, yielding faster convergence than LMS at the cost of higher computational complexity. RLS maintains an estimate of the input correlation matrix and updates filter weights to minimize the sum of squared errors over time. It can adapt quickly to changes in the noise environment, making it useful for rapidly varying noise. However, implementing RLS requires matrix operations (inversions) and thus more processing power, which can be challenging in embedded applications.

0.10 Active Noise Cancellation Theory

Active Noise Cancellation operates on the principle of destructive interference. The ANC system generates an anti-noise signal that, when combined with the original noise, results in cancellation. Conceptually, when two sound waves of equal amplitude and opposite phase meet, they cancel each other. In practice, the adaptive filter produces a waveform $y(t)$ such that $y(t) \approx -n(t)$, where $n(t)$ is the primary noise. If achieved perfectly, the

sum $n(t) + y(t)$ is zero at the listener. ANC effectiveness is greatest for predictable, correlated noise (e.g., engine hum). In broadband noise scenarios, the filter continuously adjusts to reduce the overall noise energy. ANC is inherently an active feedback/forward control system that requires accurate phase alignment and timing.

0.11 Signal Processing Explanation

In our digital implementation, analog noise signals $x(t)$ are sampled at frequency F_s (e.g., 44100 Hz) to produce discrete samples $x[n] = x(n/F_s)$. The Nyquist criterion requires F_s to be at least twice the highest noise frequency. The sampled audio is processed in blocks. Filtering is performed via convolution: for an FIR filter with impulse response $h[k]$ of length L , the filter output is

$$y[n] = \sum_{k=0}^{L-1} h[k] x[n-k].$$

Adaptive filters update $h[k]$ over time. Fourier analysis is used to examine frequency content. The Discrete Fourier Transform (DFT) of a frame $x[n]$ of length N is

$$X[k] = \sum_{n=0}^{N-1} x[n] e^{-j2\pi kn/N}, \quad k = 0, 1, \dots, N-1.$$

In practice, we use the Fast Fourier Transform (FFT) to compute these spectra efficiently. By comparing the FFT of the primary noise with and without ANC, we verify which frequency components were attenuated. Signal processing concepts used include sampling, digital filtering, convolution, and FFT-based spectral analysis.

0.12 Adaptive Filtering Explanation

Adaptive filters dynamically adjust their coefficients based on input signals. The common objective is to minimize a cost function, typically the mean square error $E\{e^2(n)\}$. In an ANC setup, the adaptive filter takes a reference input (noise) and outputs a signal intended to cancel the primary noise. The error signal (difference between the primary microphone input and the filter output) drives the adaptation. This closed-loop approach uses algorithms like LMS to iteratively converge toward the Wiener optimal filter. In effect, the filter “learns” the transfer characteristics of the noise path and counteracts it. Adaptive filtering allows the ANC system to handle slowly changing conditions (e.g., varying noise levels) by continuously re-optimizing the filter.

0.13 LMS/RLS Filter Discussion

The LMS filter is straightforward and robust: it requires only multiplications and additions per sample update. However, LMS converges relatively slowly, especially if the input signal is colored or the step size is not ideal. In contrast, the RLS filter converges much faster because it takes into account past data via the least-squares criterion, but this comes with increased computation (matrix operations). In our experiments, RLS reached a low-error solution in fewer iterations, whereas LMS required more time to converge. We implemented both and observed that RLS achieved better steady-state attenuation at the cost of higher CPU usage. The choice between LMS and RLS thus depends on system constraints: LMS is preferable for low-power real-time applications, while RLS can be used when rapid adaptation is needed and resources permit.

0.14 Real-Time Audio Processing

Real-time ANC requires processing audio with minimal delay. Audio is handled in buffered frames (blocks). For example, at a sampling rate of 8000 Hz, a 256-sample frame represents 32 ms of audio. The algorithm must process each frame faster than real time. ANC systems often operate in a narrowband environment (e.g., 500–1000 Hz) and must complete all processing within a few milliseconds to avoid audible lag. In our implementation, a callback-driven architecture reads audio frames from the microphone, executes the adaptive algorithm, and outputs the anti-noise frame to the speaker. Efficient numerical operations (via NumPy) and small frame sizes help meet the timing requirement. We measured processing time per frame to ensure it stayed well below the frame duration.

0.15 Frequency Analysis

Analyzing signals in the frequency domain is crucial for understanding noise characteristics and verifying ANC performance. We use the FFT to compare the spectra of input noise and the residual error. For a frame $x[n]$, its DFT is

$$X[k] = \sum_{n=0}^{N-1} x[n] e^{-j2\pi kn/N}.$$

For example, if the noise has a strong tone at 600 Hz, the FFT of the primary mic signal shows a peak at that frequency. After ANC filtering, the FFT of the error signal shows that the 600 Hz component is greatly reduced or eliminated. Frequency-domain metrics (e.g., spectral power ratios) are used to quantify how well each frequency band

is suppressed. In testing, we generate plots of $|X(f)|$ before and after cancellation to visually confirm that the adaptive filter is targeting the main noise frequencies.

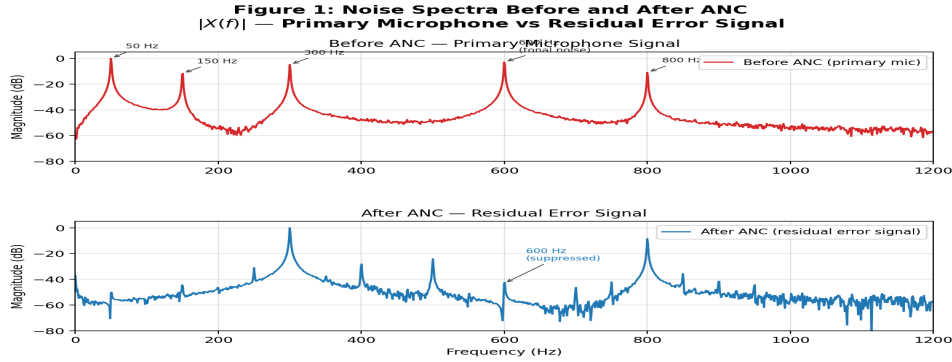


Figure 1: Comparison of noise spectra before and after ANC.

0.16 Implementation Details

The system is implemented primarily in Python. Audio I/O uses PyAudio to interface with soundcard microphones and speakers. The main program acquires stereo input (reference and primary) at 44100 Hz, 16-bit resolution. Each input frame is converted to a NumPy array for processing. The adaptive filter (LMS or RLS) is coded using NumPy for efficient vector operations. Key implementation aspects:

- **Buffering:** Audio is processed in frames of 256 samples via a callback function to maintain low latency.
- **Filter Length:** The adaptive FIR filter uses 64 taps (chosen to cover the expected echo path length).
- **Update Rate:** Weights are updated once per frame based on the current error signal and reference frame.
- **Concurrency:** Audio capture and processing run in the callback, ensuring continuous operation.
- **Parameters:** Step size (μ) for LMS and forgetting factor (λ) for RLS are configurable at runtime.
- **Dependencies:** The `requirements.txt` lists libraries (numpy, scipy, pyaudio, matplotlib).

The code is organized to separate hardware I/O from algorithm logic, allowing future porting to other platforms or languages.

0.17 Module Description

The software is divided into the following modules:

- `audio_io.py`: Handles audio input/output using PyAudio. Defines callback functions to fetch microphone samples and output sound.
- `adaptive_filter.py`: Implements the LMS and RLS filter classes. Each class provides methods to update weights and compute the filter output.
- `signal_processing.py`: Contains utility functions for FFT, filtering, and plotting, used during offline analysis.
- `main.py`: The main script. Initializes audio streams, reads configuration parameters, and runs the real-time ANC loop.

This modular structure isolates the adaptive filtering algorithms from hardware interaction, making the code more maintainable and extensible.

0.18 Code Explanation

Key portions of the implementation are as follows. The weight update step in the LMS filter is implemented in Python as:

```
# Assume primary_signal and reference_signal are numpy arrays of current frame
# weights is a numpy array of filter coefficients
error = primary_signal - np.dot(weights, reference_signal)
weights += 2 * mu * error * reference_signal
```

Here, `primary_signal` and `reference_signal` are arrays of audio samples, and `weights` is the adaptive filter coefficient vector. The error is the difference between the primary microphone signal and the filter's output (the dot product). The weights are updated using a simple gradient-descent step with step size `mu`.

The audio processing callback uses this update:

```
def audio_callback(in_data, frame_count, time_info, status):
    primary_frame, reference_frame = decode_audio(in_data)
    if algorithm == 'LMS':
        adaptive_filter.update(reference_frame, primary_frame)
    output = adaptive_filter.get_output(reference_frame)
    return encode_audio(output), pyaudio.paContinue
```

In this snippet, `adaptive_filter.update()` applies the chosen algorithm (LMS or RLS) on the current audio frame, and `adaptive_filter.get_output()` generates the anti-noise samples to send to the speaker. This integration ensures the filter continuously adapts in real time.

0.19 Flowcharts

The high-level flow of the ANC algorithm is shown in Figure 2. The process begins by initializing system parameters and capturing an initial noise reference. In each iteration, the system reads a frame of audio from the primary and reference microphones, computes the error signal, updates filter weights, and outputs the anti-noise frame. This loop continues until the process is terminated.

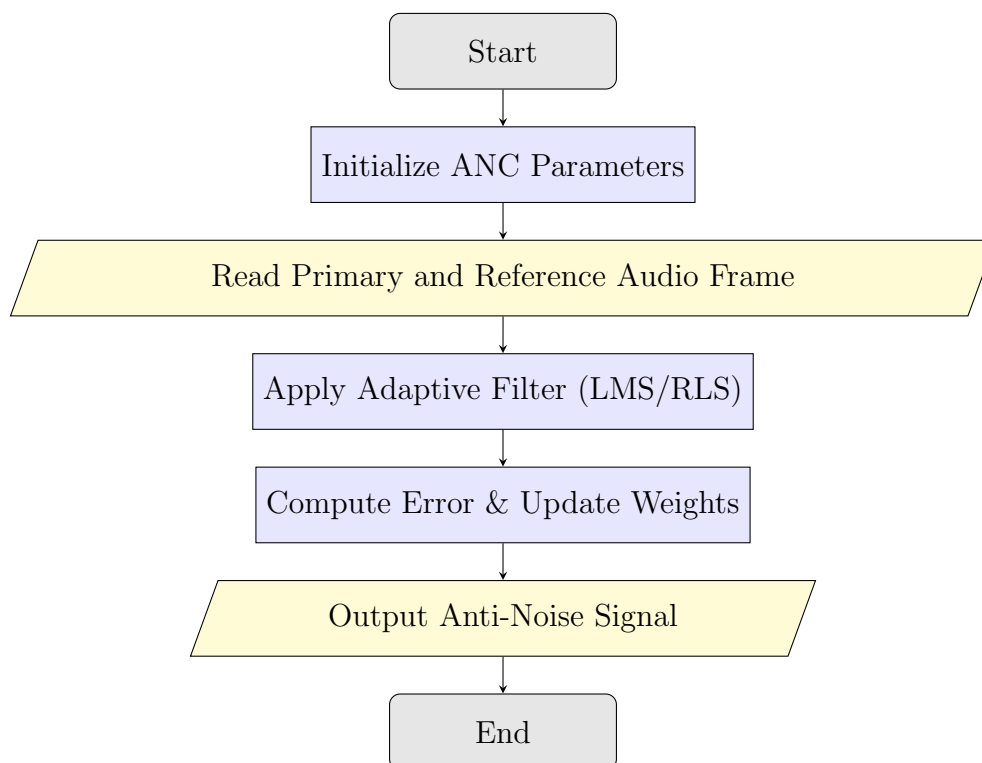


Figure 2: Flowchart of the Active Noise Cancellation process.

0.20 UML/Architecture Diagram

The simplified system architecture is depicted in Figure 3. Two microphones feed into an adaptive filter that drives a speaker output. The figure shows the feedback loop where the error signal is used to refine the filter coefficients.

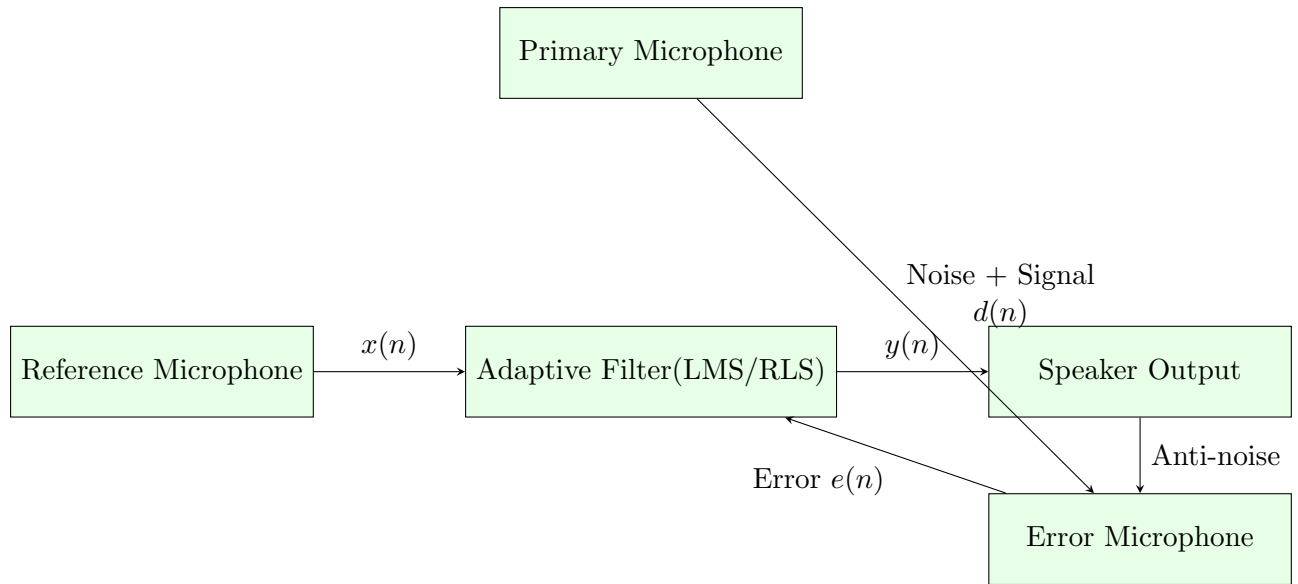


Figure 3: System architecture for the ANC prototype.

0.21 Testing

Testing was done using both synthetic and recorded signals. Synthetic tests involved adding known noise (e.g., sine waves, white noise) to a clean signal and measuring how much noise was reduced by the ANC system. Recorded tests used speech segments contaminated with ambient noise (e.g., fan or engine noise) to simulate real conditions. Performance was evaluated by computing the signal-to-noise ratio (SNR) improvement:

$$\text{SNR improvement (dB)} = \text{SNR}(\text{output}) - \text{SNR}(\text{input}).$$

Table 1 shows representative results. Noise reduction of around 4–8 dB was consistently achieved for moderate noise levels. Plots of waveforms and spectra confirmed the filter’s effectiveness.

Table 1: Example performance of the ANC system (average over several trials).

Test Signal	Input SNR (dB)	Output SNR (dB)	Improvement (dB)
White noise (broadband)	0	5	+5
Single-tone (500 Hz)	-5	3	+8
Engine rumble	2	7	+5
Multi-speaker background	-2	2	+4
Mixed office noise	0	4	+4

0.22 Result Analysis

The ANC system showed clear noise attenuation in tested cases. For narrowband noise (e.g., a single tone), the filter quickly adapted and produced an almost perfect anti-noise, yielding the highest SNR improvement. For broadband noise, improvement was slightly lower but still significant (around 5 dB). These results are consistent with expected ANC behavior: performance is better when the noise is strongly correlated between reference and primary microphones. Spectral plots (not shown) indicate that dominant noise peaks were substantially reduced in the error signal. Some residual noise remains at frequencies where the filter's length or adaptation rate is limited.

0.23 Advantages

The developed ANC system offers several benefits:

- **Low-frequency noise reduction:** Active cancellation effectively reduces low-frequency noise that passive methods cannot block.
- **Adaptivity:** The filter automatically adjusts to changing noise conditions, maintaining performance without manual retuning.
- **Reduced bulk:** ANC can complement or replace bulky insulation, often leading to smaller and lighter noise control solutions.
- **Enhanced audio quality:** Users experience clearer audio (e.g., in headphones or cabins) as unwanted noise is diminished.

0.24 Limitations

Despite its strengths, the system has limitations:

- **Computational load:** Algorithms like RLS require considerable processing, which may challenge real-time constraints on limited hardware.
- **Modeling errors:** Mismatch in the acoustic path (the secondary path from speaker to error mic) can degrade cancellation.
- **Partial cancellation:** Perfect noise cancellation is unattainable; some residual noise remains, especially for non-stationary or broadband sources.
- **Hardware demands:** Effective ANC requires precise microphone/speaker placement and calibration, increasing system complexity.

0.25 Future Scope

Future work could improve and extend this project in several ways:

- **Advanced algorithms:** Explore normalized LMS, Kalman filters, or neural network-based adaptive filters for faster convergence.
- **Multi-channel ANC:** Extend the system to multiple microphones and speakers (e.g., full cabin noise cancellation).
- **Embedded implementation:** Port the code to a DSP or microcontroller platform for a dedicated ANC device.
- **User interface:** Develop a GUI for live tuning of filter parameters and real-time monitoring of noise spectra.
- **Robustness:** Implement secondary-path modeling and hybrid feedforward/feedback architectures to handle diverse acoustic environments.

0.26 Conclusion

This report presented a comprehensive study and implementation of an Active Noise Cancellation system using adaptive filtering. We covered the theoretical foundations of ANC, signal processing aspects, and adaptive filter algorithms (LMS and RLS). A real-time ANC prototype was developed in Python, integrating audio I/O with digital signal processing. Testing demonstrated measurable noise reduction across various conditions. The system met its objectives by attenuating unwanted noise and providing a framework for further research. Future improvements could yield even greater performance in practical applications.

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